



POLITICS IN NIGERIA

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IN

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DEDICATION

To all citizens of Nigeria committed to national progress.

PREFACE

Politics in Nigeria! There is no way we can discuss Nigerian politics without mentioning the keyword “Democracy.”

The word democracy comes from the Greek words ‘demos’, meaning people, and ‘kratos’, meaning power. Hence, democracy can be understood as the “power of the people,” a way of governing that depends on the will of the people.

According to Schumpeter (1947), democracy means that the people can accept or reject those who are to govern them. By this, democracy implies conducting elections and choosing leaders who will represent the majority.

Democracy is government by the people. It is a form of government in which supreme power is vested in the people and exercised directly by them or through their elected agents under a free electoral system.

Before democracy in Nigeria, the system of governance was based on military rule. During those periods, absolute power rested solely with the government. The opinion of the people could not dictate government decisions because there was no opportunity to vote or be voted for, and there was no concept of political parties.

However, democracy makes it possible for citizens to be actively involved in choosing their leaders. Hence, people participate in the process of forming a government. They have free will and the right to vote for parties and leaders of their choice. And this right is universal and is not restricted by wealth, social class, or ethnicity.

In a democratic system, different parties present a manifesto or a set of ideas about how a country should be governed. Thus, a democratic government is formed when a majority of people support a particular party as the ruling party.

Undoubtedly, the democratic system of government is a demonstration of political activity. Thus, politics can be described as the activities involved in the making of government or the functioning of government.

Politics is a broad institution comprising different categories of people with varying ideologies. Politics may be bound by certain rules and regulations, yet its deeper activities require intelligence and participation.

So, what can we say about political activity in Nigeria? Everything about these activities (both cunning and unwise) is what will be discussed in this book.

Therefore, this book will focus on four major topics:

- ❖ Political parties
- ❖ Elections
- ❖ Appointments
- ❖ Governance

GOVERNANCE

Governance refers to the act of governing or ruling. It is the set of rules, laws, and procedures framed by a government and implemented through the representatives of the state. In this sense, governance provides the framework within which government policies and regulations are carried out.

Governance cannot be discussed without reference to government, because governance represents the practical exercise of political authority, while government is the body through which this authority is exercised.

Government can therefore be described as the group of persons that constitute the governing authority of a political unit or organisation. It is an established system of political administration through which a nation, state, district, or other political entity is governed. Government functions as an institution made up of individuals responsible for managing and administering the affairs of a country or state. Every government operates under a constitution or a set of fundamental principles designed to ensure effective governance.

Government is responsible for governing, which involves exercising authority over the policies, actions, and affairs of a state, organisation, or people. One of the core responsibilities of government is ensuring the security of its citizens through effective legislation. This includes establishing and managing a competent police force, a fair judicial system, and a strong defence structure.

Other responsibilities of government include providing basic social amenities and developing infrastructure to support social welfare, healthcare, and national development. In addition, government is expected to manage the economy effectively by controlling inflation, maintaining adequate foreign reserves, and encouraging foreign investment.

The responsibilities of government towards its people are extensive. They range from formulating effective policies to providing public amenities. And to ensure efficiency and proper administration, government responsibilities are divided across different levels.

In Nigeria, for example, there are three tiers of government: the federal government, which is the first tier; the state government, which is the second tier; and the local government, which constitutes the third tier. Therefore, when discussing government in Nigeria, it does not refer only to the President, governors, or local government chairpersons. Government is a collective term that includes elected officials and political appointees across all sectors and levels.

Furthermore, government has a responsibility to protect the environment from further degradation. This includes safeguarding and cleaning local and international water bodies, establishing wildlife sanctuaries, and investing in renewable sources of energy and power.

Unfortunately, in Nigeria, many of these responsibilities are treated as extraordinary achievements rather than basic obligations. The structure of governance often makes it easy for leaders to neglect their duties, and when any responsibility is fulfilled, it is sometimes presented as a major accomplishment worthy of excessive publicity.

Turning to the practice of governance in Nigeria, it must be stated that the overall standard of governance remains significantly below expectation. What government administrations often describe as their best achievements frequently fall short of what is reasonably expected from a functional government.

In Nigeria, three major responsibilities are commonly expected of government: ensuring security against internal and external threats, maintaining law and order, and providing basic amenities for citizens. Sadly, no government administration, past or present, can confidently claim to have fully met these obligations. To explain the nature of governance in Nigeria, it is important to examine these responsibilities individually.

Starting with security, public discourse has shifted from discussions of safety to concerns about widespread insecurity. The level

of insecurity across the country has become a serious issue with no clear solution in sight. Security threats now include banditry, the killing of innocent and unarmed citizens, kidnapping, armed robbery, political violence, rape, murder, harassment by law enforcement agents, cultism, and other related crimes.

As a result of these security challenges, many lives have been lost, countless individuals live in fear and distress, properties are destroyed, businesses are pushed to the brink of collapse, infrastructure is damaged, and the economy continues to decline. Nigeria's international reputation has also suffered significantly. And if decisive actions are not taken, there is a strong likelihood that insecurity will continue to worsen, as current efforts by the government remain inadequate.

Although some people may believe that their locations are relatively secure, they often fail to recognise that the absence of immediate threats does not guarantee long-term safety.

In this modern and technologically advanced era, it is disappointing that both past administrations in Nigeria have failed to utilise available technological tools effectively to combat and reduce insecurity. The inability to harness technology for intelligence gathering, surveillance, and crime prevention reflects a significant weakness in governance.

It is particularly concerning when journalists interview elected public office holders on issues of insecurity and the responses offered focus more on describing the threats than outlining concrete solutions. When those entrusted with reassuring citizens and addressing insecurity appear to be complaining, it raises serious questions about the purpose of their continued occupation of public office.

Reducing internal security threats to the lowest possible level in a country such as Nigeria should not be an insurmountable task if the rule of law is properly enforced. Maintaining law and order ought to be a top priority in efforts to curb criminal activities. Unfortunately, the application of the rule of law in Nigeria often falls short of what is required to address the prevailing security challenges.

Often, only a fraction of offenders are apprehended by law enforcement agencies. Among those brought before the courts, case resolution is slow, with many proceedings abandoned or prolonged due to various influences. In some situations, suspects are detained without prosecution or released without trial. This pattern undermines deterrence and encourages further criminal activity.

In recent times, reports have emerged of bandits arrested for killing innocent citizens, destroying property, and instilling fear across communities. Even members of the armed forces have lost their lives in efforts to contain these threats. Yet, the public is sometimes confronted with news suggesting that such individuals may be rehabilitated or

sponsored abroad after claiming to have surrendered. This further undermines confidence in the justice system.

Over the years, several politicians, business leaders, influential individuals, and former public office holders have been accused of various unlawful activities. However, convictions remain rare. Despite the widespread acknowledgement of corruption among political office holders, very few individuals have been held accountable. When wrongdoing goes largely unpunished, it weakens public trust and encourages further misconduct.

Failure to enforce the law effectively not only sustains existing criminal activities but also creates an environment in which crime continues to grow. This situation accurately reflects the current reality in Nigeria.

Beyond insecurity and weak law enforcement, governance in Nigeria cannot be fully examined without addressing the issue of inadequate social amenities and infrastructure. Essential services such as efficient transport systems, stable electricity, well-equipped healthcare facilities, functional educational institutions, a healthy business environment, effective drainage systems, and adequate housing are critical for economic development and crime reduction.

Sadly, these amenities are unevenly distributed across the country. Many communities, despite being richly endowed with natural resources, remain among the poorest in Nigeria. This imbalance has

contributed significantly to criminal activities, particularly where citizens feel deprived of resources that should benefit them.

While insecurity exists nationwide, the intensity varies across locations. Some cities record little or no incidents of kidnapping or armed robbery, whereas others experience such threats daily. A key factor explaining this disparity is the level of infrastructure and availability of basic amenities.

Where infrastructure is absent or poorly maintained, the production chain is disrupted. This disruption hampers development and results in economic decline, low standards of living, unemployment, and rising costs of goods. These conditions, in turn, push many individuals towards criminal activities as a means of survival.

In summary, insecurity, weak enforcement of law and order, and inadequate social amenities collectively characterise governance in Nigeria. The country has experienced successive administrations marked by poor governance, and the consequences of this failure continue to shape national life. This reality leads directly to the next discussion on the effects of bad governance in Nigeria.

The various effects of bad governance include insecurity, underdevelopment, rising levels of corruption, a poor education system, gross injustice, including the abuse of human rights, increased

migration, declining trust in political processes, business failure, and many others.

Poverty and economic stagnation are also significant consequences of bad governance. In situations where a nation's collective wealth is concentrated in the hands of a few individuals, often the political elite and their associates, widespread poverty becomes inevitable. Similarly, when funds allocated for infrastructure development are embezzled, economic growth is stifled. This leads to job losses, reduced sources of livelihood, and, in the long run, deepening poverty among citizens.

Another major consequence of bad governance in Nigeria is the loss of international reputation. In the past, Nigeria was respected within the international community, and its citizens were held in high esteem. This can no longer be said today. The country has lost much of its global influence, and Nigerians are often subjected to excessive and dehumanising scrutiny abroad. In some instances, Nigeria is cited as a reference point when discussing poor governance. These developments are clear indicators of governance failure.

Having examined the effects of bad governance in Nigeria, it is necessary to ask why governments often appear comfortable neglecting their responsibilities. Several factors contribute to this situation, which leads to the next discussion: the reasons for bad governance in Nigeria.

One major factor influencing bad governance is the quality of elected leaders. The competence of an elected official largely determines how governance is carried out. When individuals who lack the capacity or willingness to govern effectively are elected into office, poor performance should not come as a surprise.

There are individuals whose primary concerns revolve around personal comfort and minimal responsibility. When such individuals seek political office, questions naturally arise about their preparedness and the advice guiding their ambitions.

Regardless of age, a critical trait that contributes to bad governance is poor judgement. Leaders who lack sound judgement often struggle to make objective decisions. Many politicians are unable to act impartially due to biases rooted in religion, ethnicity, or party affiliation. It is important to note that this challenge is not age-specific, as poor judgement can be found among both young and older politicians.

When elected officials exhibit these shortcomings, it becomes difficult for them to discharge their duties effectively. This reality underscores the need for stronger accountability mechanisms, as earlier suggested.

Another contributing factor to bad governance in Nigeria is the Constitution. As the supreme law of the land, the Constitution defines

the structure, powers, and responsibilities of government. Ideally, all government actions should align with its provisions.

However, in practice, the Constitution is often used as a protective shield by those in power. While no section of the Constitution explicitly supports bad governance, certain provisions, particularly those relating to immunity, make it difficult to hold public officials accountable. This limitation contributes significantly to the persistence of ineffective governance.

Political appointees also play a critical role in governance outcomes. Every appointee is assigned specific responsibilities as part of the governing structure. Bad governance is reinforced when appointees lack understanding of their roles or deliberately neglect their duties. Some occupy positions without clear knowledge of their functions, while others choose not to perform them.

In some countries, competent leaders may be elected but undermined by poor appointments, or the reverse may occur. In Nigeria's case, both the selection of leaders and the appointment of officials are often flawed, worsening governance outcomes.

These factors collectively explain the persistence of bad governance in Nigeria. However, identifying the problem alone is insufficient. The focus must shift towards solutions.

Although the scale of Nigeria's challenges may appear overwhelming, meaningful change begins with deliberate action. And

the responsibility does not rest solely on the government. While government bears the greater burden, citizens also have an essential role to play.

Consequently, the remaining sections of this book will examine the responsibilities of citizens in building a better Nigeria and propose practical solutions for improved governance.

Starting with the responsibilities of citizens, it is important to first clarify who citizens are. Citizens form the backbone of a democratic system. In a democracy, the power to effect change lies more with the people than with elected officeholders. However, many Nigerians are unaware of this reality and often assume that power rests solely with politicians. This misconception arises largely because citizen participation has not been taken seriously.

The truth is that citizens can collectively make a positive impact on the nation. What people choose to do, or fail to do, today will determine the future of the country and that of the next generation. Citizen participation is a pillar of democracy and is essential for its sustainability.

Participation in governance is both a civic duty and an honour. And at this critical moment in Nigeria, citizens have the capacity to influence positive change through active engagement.

Thus, one of the primary obligations of a citizen is obedience to the law. Laws exist to protect individuals, their communities, and their

property. Therefore, responsible citizenship requires respect for these laws. Acts such as harming others, destroying property, kidnapping, stealing, fighting, and violating traffic regulations do not reflect good citizenship. If citizens across the country were to obey the law consistently, many of Nigeria's challenges would be significantly reduced.

Respecting the rights, beliefs, and opinions of others is another key responsibility of citizens. Nigeria is a diverse society with people holding different views and beliefs. It is unrealistic to expect universal agreement. While disagreements may be frustrating, it is important to recognise that diversity of thought is a natural part of human society. Rather than imposing opinions, citizens should seek to educate, engage, and coexist peacefully.

Participation in the political process is another vital civic responsibility. Unfortunately, poor governance has discouraged many citizens from meaningful engagement. Participation is often wrongly limited to voting during elections, whereas it also includes other activities that contribute to development. Community involvement, for example, allows citizens to contribute to local progress by identifying areas that require improvement and offering their skills, knowledge, and time to community organisations, committees, and development projects.

Additional responsibilities of citizens include cooperating with authorities in maintaining peace, protecting public property, supporting national defence, and contributing to crime prevention.

In concluding the discussion on citizens' responsibilities, emphasis must also be placed on self-development and self-examination. Many individuals criticise government actions while engaging in behaviours that mirror the very problems they condemn. Corruption is frequently criticised at the national level, yet some individuals rely on dishonest practices for personal gain. Observations of student politics in some universities further suggest that poor leadership habits can begin at an early stage if left unchecked.

Citizens often accuse government officials of abusing power, yet similar behaviour is sometimes displayed by individuals within their own limited positions of authority. While criticism of government can be constructive, personal development is equally important. Self-development refers to the conscious effort to improve oneself in various aspects of life, including skills, behaviour, and psychological growth. It is a necessary process for individual and societal progress and often occurs through self-examination and honest assessment of one's strengths and weaknesses.

Having examined the responsibilities of citizens, it is equally important to consider the obligations of government. Government is the institution responsible for governance, and the true measure of

leadership lies in the ability of political officeholders to solve problems and make sound decisions. This applies to presidents, governors, legislators, local government chairpersons, political appointees, and all those entrusted with public authority.

Ideally, the duties of government are carried out collectively to ensure effective governance for the benefit of all citizens. However, when relationships among political officeholders are driven primarily by political loyalty rather than accountability, serious problems arise. Over the years, analyses of past administrations reveal that excessive political alliances among officeholders often weaken checks and balances. This makes proper scrutiny, criticism, and accountability difficult, thereby undermining good governance.

Political parties frequently centralise control of government within a single party. This raises concerns about why political parties sometimes begin to plan the sharing of key political positions even before elections are conducted. Examples include arrangements over positions such as Executive President and Senate President, or state governors and Speakers of the House of Assembly.

Ideally, the relationship between these institutions of government should remain calm, reflecting a system where checks and balances operate effectively. In Nigeria, however, this calm relationship does not guarantee accountability, because political office holders often

neglect their constitutional responsibilities, allowing misconduct to go unchallenged.

Governance problems tend to emerge when a single political party dominates both the executive and legislative arms of government. In situations where the President and the Senate President belong to the same political party and operate within the same party structure, accountability is often weakened. As a result, failures in governance may go unchallenged, and misconduct may be overlooked.

In a democratic system, effective governance is more achievable when power is distributed across multiple political parties. This promotes balance, accountability, and institutional independence. Therefore, if the President of a country emerges from a particular political party, it would be preferable for the elected Senate President to come from a different party. The same principle should apply at the state level, where governors and Speakers of the House of Assembly should ideally belong to different political parties.

The objective of this arrangement is to prevent monopoly of power and to promote healthy governance. And, this leads to the broader discussion on proposing solutions for improving governance in Nigeria. Thus, the discussion focuses on the legislature, the judiciary, the mass media, and the three tiers of government.

Beginning with the legislature, this arm of government is also known as the National Assembly. In Nigeria, the National Assembly

consists of 109 Senators and 360 members of the House of Representatives. The legislature is responsible for electing its leadership, enacting laws, overseeing the activities of the executive, and providing a platform where representatives of the people can debate national issues openly.

The National Assembly plays a crucial role in governance, as its decisions and attitudes towards national issues shape not only present governance but also future political direction. Many of the challenges currently facing the country stem from past policy failures, which successive administrations have often failed to correct.

National issues such as corruption, insecurity, and poor political appointments continue to undermine governance. Taking corruption as an example, legislative measures can be enforced to curb corrupt practices among public office holders.

One notable difference between developed countries and developing countries such as Nigeria lies in the effectiveness of their legal systems. A major weakness of Nigerian laws is that many are adopted without adequate adaptation to local realities. For instance, if two communities with equal populations experience significantly different crime rates, applying the same legal measures to both may produce unequal results. Thus, laws must therefore reflect the specific social and economic conditions of the society in which they operate.

Legal frameworks that were effective decades ago may require review and adjustment to meet contemporary challenges.

As the law-making arm of government, the legislature should enact laws that not only punish offenders but also ensure that no individual is exempt from the law. Although many laws already exist, gaps within them often allow political office holders to exploit loopholes and evade justice. These shortcomings must be addressed, as good governance is anchored on the supremacy of the rule of law over both the governed and those in authority.

Thus, the rule of law is fundamental to achieving good governance. Strengthening its enforcement could resolve a substantial proportion of Nigeria's governance challenges. In Nigeria, numerous laws exist but are poorly enforced. If these laws were properly implemented, the country would experience a significant reduction in criminal and illegal activities.

The rule of law has the capacity to curb insecurity, corruption, and other forms of crime. However, its effectiveness largely depends on the efficiency and independence of the judiciary. This brings the discussion to proposed solutions for the judiciary arm of government.

The judiciary is the third arm of government, alongside the executive and the legislature. It comprises the Supreme Court of Nigeria, the Court of Appeal, the High Courts, and other trial courts, including Magistrate, Customary, Sharia, and other specialised courts.

The primary role of the judiciary is to uphold the rule of law and ensure the supremacy of the constitution. Thus, it is responsible for interpreting laws enacted by the legislature and applying them to individual cases, as well as resolving disputes between citizens or between citizens and the government.

However, what can we say about the judiciary in Nigeria? To be honest, the performance of the judiciary in Nigeria has remained below expectations. As a result, one of the factors contributing to unlawful activities in the country is the judiciary itself.

Many individuals commit unlawful acts with relative ease because they can exploit influence, bribery, and other corrupt practices. The judiciary, which is meant to function as an independent arm of government, is often affected by corruption, political and social influence, and other unlawful actions.

Although various challenges affect the judicial system, there are also solutions to address these issues. Thus, this section will focus on four major measures.

Firstly, every possible effort should be made to eradicate corruption across all levels of the judiciary. Corruption is one of the most significant obstacles to a fair and effective court system. Reducing corrupt practices requires appropriate punishment for all parties involved, both givers and receivers. A judiciary free from corruption ensures fair hearing and justice.

Secondly, employing more legal practitioners could help reduce the backlog of pending cases. One major factor contributing to the high number of pending cases is the excessive workload of individual judges. While some cases naturally require extensive investigation, many could be resolved within a few weeks. Long delays often result in unjust detention or prolonged uncertainty for many citizens. Therefore, increasing the number of qualified legal practitioners is essential to promote efficiency in the judiciary.

Thirdly, providing adequate welfare for judicial staff is essential. Many problems arise due to poor working conditions, inadequate facilities, insecurity, and low income. Some individuals are tempted into corrupt practices because of financial pressures. For example, a client might offer a sum exceeding a judge's annual income to influence a case. Strengthening salaries, improving working conditions, ensuring security, and upgrading technological facilities can significantly reduce such risks and enhance the delivery of justice.

Lastly, continuous training and professional development should be prioritised. Legal trends, laws, and practices evolve over time, and what was standard ten years ago may be outdated today. Regular seminars sessions will ensure that judicial officers remain informed and competent. Additionally, the adoption of technology can greatly improve efficiency. Technology facilitates research, case management, information retrieval, record keeping, and even court hearings through online processes.

Moving on to mass media, the first question is: what is mass media? Media is a means of communication that transmits information from a source to a target audience. Thus, any media intended for a large audience is referred to as mass media.

Mass media includes the press, television, radio, social media, digital platforms, and the internet. Organisations that manage these technologies, such as publishing companies and film studios, are also considered part of the mass media.

Over the years, mass media has played a crucial role in Nigeria's socio-political and economic development and is often called the fourth arm of government. Media acts as an intermediary between the government and the public. Its primary objectives are to inform, educate, promote awareness, and uphold accountability.

Thus, when mass media diligently performs its duties, it serves the public interest. However, when media activities deviate from their intended purpose, they can become tools for manipulation or destruction.

In Nigeria, media responsibilities are sometimes undermined, and press freedom is occasionally curtailed. Journalists face obstacles such as threats, bribery, political influence, and individual pressures. Many lose their lives, jobs, or personal safety while attempting to carry out their professional duties.

State-owned broadcasting stations often strictly control content before publication. Reports focus on federal government challenges, while local or state-level issues, such as unpaid workers' salaries, receive little attention. Similarly, private media organisations operate under external pressures and must balance business strategies with caution due to potential threats.

These examples highlight some of the problems associated with the mass media, demonstrating that current practices often fall short of professional standards. As a result, improvement across all sectors of the media is clearly necessary. This raises important questions: Are the mass media fulfilling their responsibilities? Yes. Are they performing at their best? No. So, what must they do to achieve their full potential?

Professionalism is a key requirement for growth in any occupation. Humans naturally have different opinions and emotions; what makes one person happy may make another unhappy. Professionalism, however, ensures moderation and consistency. Thus, adhering to professional standards and norms should guide all activities of the media.

Furthermore, the media can carry out additional responsibilities without bias, contributing positively to the country. One such suggestion is that the media should monitor the activities of the judiciary and law enforcement agencies. In Nigeria today, judicial

manipulation and corruption are prevalent, and the media can play a vital role in exposing and reducing such practices.

The mass media can contribute in three key ways. Firstly, they can uncover cases of unfair justice, including law enforcement brutality, unlawful arrests or punishments, unjust court orders, and other unlawful practices. Secondly, they can monitor and follow up on pending cases, many of which are intentionally delayed due to influence and corruption, resulting in unjust punishment for some individuals. Thirdly, the media can track concluded cases to ensure that sentences are enforced, as some convicted individuals evade punishment due to influence.

Having discussed the legislature, judiciary, and the media, the discussion naturally shifts to solutions for governance at the federal, state, and local levels. Generalising “government” would not provide a clear understanding of the solutions. Therefore, this section focuses on governance at each level.

Starting with local government, this is often considered the lowest tier of government but is arguably the most important. Local government can be likened to the foundation of a building: its strength directly affects the stability of the entire structure.

Nigeria has 774 local government areas (LGAs), each administered by a local government council consisting of a chairman, who serves as the chief executive, and elected Councilors. Each LGA is

subdivided into ten to twenty Wards, with a Councilor overseeing each Ward and reporting to the LGA Chairman. Councilors form the legislative arm of the local government.

The primary aim of local government is to generate revenue to maintain, improve, and develop local infrastructure and community services. Local governments were created to bring governance closer to the people at the grassroots. They are responsible for services related to roads, traffic, primary healthcare, planning, housing, economic and community development, recreation, fire services, and more.

Sadly, many of these responsibilities are neglected by local government councils. The bodies tasked with developing infrastructure often contribute to its deterioration, largely due to poor regulation and the absence of proper checks and accountability mechanisms.

While these issues are significant, it is important to recognise that the core responsibilities of local governments are relatively straightforward compared to higher tiers of government. Although challenges such as limited independence and inadequate revenue hinder their effectiveness, these obstacles can be addressed through practical and well-structured reforms.

Key steps for improvement include establishing transparent structures across all local sectors. For instance, revenue collection should follow clear procedures for receipt, remittance, recording, and auditing, as weak systems make it easy to misappropriate funds.

Likewise, improving infrastructure and community services does not necessarily require large expenditure; efficient planning and management can deliver significant results.

Once again, structural arrangements supported by effective planning, public awareness, and strong partnerships are key to achieving significant progress. For example, in reducing floods, improving roads, and maintaining a clean environment, proper governance can make a tangible difference. Even though I have not travelled to all states in the country, my experiences in a few locations are enough to demonstrate that poor drainage systems not only cause flooding but also damage roads, properties, and the environment.

Using my own community as a case study, there are no properly maintained roads, no functional drainage systems, and inadequate sanitary measures to keep the environment clean. In this situation, the local government council could make a substantial impact by implementing cost-effective measures. While citizens contribute to some environmental problems, one of the core reasons for government existence is to prevent and manage such challenges.

It is puzzling why some individuals construct houses without providing proper drainage in front of their buildings, and some even extend their structures into areas reserved for drainage. Others deliberately dispose of waste into drainage systems or expand their

buildings onto major roads. These problems persist largely because the government fails to perform its duties effectively.

Local governments often overlook the importance of small, preventive measures, believing that millions of naira must be budgeted before any meaningful action can be taken. Yet attention to minor issues can yield significant benefits.

Turning to security at the local level, minor acts of crime and insecurity across communities are often ignored, but they have the potential to escalate into larger problems. Preventing insecurity should be a major responsibility of government because the minor crimes and illegal activities neglected today can contribute to widespread violence in the future, a pattern evident in Nigeria.

A major contributor to these problems is the role of traditional and community leaders. In many instances, these leaders are indirectly responsible for local insecurity. To address this, government must regulate and establish a strong partnership with traditional and community leaders. Local government is best positioned to facilitate this relationship, as these leaders are often closer to the people than elected officials. A strong network between government and local leadership can form the foundation for preventing criminal activity.

Thus, it is essential to determine how the government can establish a robust and collaborative relationship with community leaders to curb all forms of criminal activity.

First, traditional and community leaders should be educated on the responsibilities of their positions. Leadership should not rely solely on family lineage; if a role serves no broader purpose, the government could appoint community leaders with clearly defined tasks.

Second, traditional and community leaders should be included in the government payroll. This reduces the incentive to engage in illegal activities to generate income, ensuring they are accountable in performing their duties.

Third, the government should create avenues for efficient networking among law enforcement agencies, traditional and community leaders, and government officials. Such collaboration will enable all parties to carry out their responsibilities more effectively.

Finally, traditional leaders must be monitored and held accountable for any criminal activities. Many criminals partner with traditional leaders because these figures are perceived to face little scrutiny. The lack of arrests or enforcement measures against them often emboldens illegal behaviour.

Moving on, it is equally important to consider governance at the state level in Nigeria. State governments control subdivisions within the federal system and share political power with the federal government. Thus, understanding this tier is crucial to analysing how governance functions across different levels in Nigeria.

Nigeria is divided into 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory, where the country's capital, Abuja, is located. Each state has an elected Governor and legislature.

The responsibilities of state governments include generating revenue, promoting economic growth, establishing healthcare facilities, ensuring the security of lives and property, providing basic amenities, creating an enabling environment for businesses, and funding educational institutions. If these responsibilities were diligently carried out across the country, Nigeria would become a more suitable environment for all its citizens.

To analyse and propose solutions for sustainable development across the states, I will focus on five major areas.

Firstly, appointments. Appointments are a major determinant of governance. The progress or failure of any government is largely influenced by the competence of its political appointees. While governments rarely intend to appoint individuals who would undermine their administration, many appointments are nevertheless driven by political loyalty rather than merit, creating challenges across various sectors.

Secondly, infrastructure. This refers to the basic facilities and services needed for a society to function effectively, including roads, utilities, and public amenities. Infrastructure is essential for faster

economic growth and poverty reduction, as it increases productivity, facilitates trade and connectivity, and promotes economic inclusion.

In Nigeria, infrastructure provision faces significant challenges. Abandoned or uncompleted projects are common, often due to political differences, corruption, or personal interests. For example, some state leaders may neglect projects initiated by predecessors from opposing political parties, or start new projects close to elections to use them as campaign strategies, with no intention of completing them. Development should be a priority for every government, and the same effort used to start new projects should be applied to completing existing ones.

Thirdly, payment and salaries. Timely payment of salaries, pensions, contracts, and allowances is a key responsibility of government. Delays in payment are frequent and often justified by bureaucratic excuses. In some cases, payments are intentionally delayed for personal financial gain, such as investing funds to earn short-term interest. Correcting these practices is essential for good governance and public trust.

Fourthly, education. The Nigerian educational system is complex and faces multiple challenges, including underfunding, poor welfare for staff and students, and infrastructural deficiencies. While some debate whether the government can fully fund education, it is undeniable that the government has a fundamental responsibility to

provide sufficient resources to ensure a functional and equitable educational system.

If government officials consider the educational burden too great, a simple solution exists: all government officials in Nigeria could voluntarily contribute a percentage of their salaries and allowances to reduce the financial strain on education. If they are unwilling to make this sacrifice, they should not avoid their responsibility to fund education fully.

Funding educational development should be a top priority for every government. The quality of Nigeria's educational system directly influences the country's growth. Even with current allocations, however, inefficiencies persist, as funds are often invested in irrelevant or poorly structured. Therefore, achieving a robust educational system requires both adequate funding and an effective organisational structure.

Finally, attention must be given to addressing security challenges across Nigeria. Insecurity and criminal activities remain major setbacks in every sector. Finding long-term solutions should be a priority for government.

Why is it often easy to commit unlawful acts in Nigeria? Why is it difficult to prevent crime? Why do law enforcement agencies ignore certain cases? Why is it easier to chase criminals after offences rather than prevent them? These questions must be asked to identify effective solutions to insecurity.

One of the main obstacles to reducing crime is the reactive mindset of law enforcement, which focuses on responding after crimes are committed rather than preventing them. Regardless of the skills, equipment, training, or partnerships available to them, their efforts will remain inefficient without proper preventative measures.

Preventing crime should not be a prolonged or reactive process. With adequate planning and proactive strategies, addressing criminal activities would become significantly easier. No location should be beyond monitoring by law enforcement, whether on land, in the air, or even at sea. Unfortunately, in Nigeria, secure monitoring often extends only to areas occupied by political officeholders.

Tackling criminal activity should be comprehensive. The lives and properties of citizens are as important as those of the government. Effective measures require proper training of personnel, the use of modern technology, adequate equipment, and welfare provisions. Currently, many law enforcement officers rely solely on weapons to exert authority and often harass civilians unnecessarily. Strength should extend beyond firearms to include physical, social, and psychological competence.

Inadequate security equipment remains a major obstacle. Without modern tools and technology, criminal activities continue to rise. Proper investment in technological solutions and welfare for law enforcement officers would greatly enhance effectiveness. Other

important measures include secure border systems, partnerships with local authorities, and extensive inter-agency collaboration.

The final discussion in this section focuses on governance at the federal level. The federal government, led by the President, exercises executive power and handles matters of national concern, including defence, foreign affairs, and monetary policy. Responsibilities also encompass maintaining law and order, protecting lives and property, administering justice, regulating the military and armed forces, providing welfare services, promoting economic development, creating employment opportunities, levying taxes, managing transport and electricity, developing agriculture, overseeing education, and regulating telecommunications.

While the federal government undertakes these responsibilities, it is legitimate to question whether they are fulfilling them effectively. After more than twenty years of democracy, it is difficult to identify a single area where performance meets expectations. Governance is not a simple task, yet when evaluating various sectors, progress appears minimal and, in some cases, regressive.

When discussing the proposed solutions at the state government level in previous sections, the federal government also faces similar challenges. At the federal level, wrong appointments are still made, infrastructure across the country remains inadequate, and delays in the payment of salaries, pensions, and contracts are common.

Insecurity is increasing daily, and the federal education system continues to face its own challenges. These are just a few areas where the federal government must channel greater effort.

In addition to the five proposed solutions discussed earlier, which also apply to the federal government, I propose four additional measures that require attention.

The first is the expansion of correctional centres across Nigeria. In a country with high rates of criminal activity, the number of convicts is inevitably rising. Correctional facilities must provide adequate space for different categories of offenders, as punishments vary according to the severity of the crime. Currently, different categories of convicts are often housed together, which undermines the rehabilitative purpose of prisons. Instead of reforming offenders, some facilities inadvertently become places where convicts can learn advanced criminal skills from one another.

For example, if a person convicted of a minor robbery shares a cell with inmates charged with armed robbery, kidnapping, or terrorism, they may learn new criminal techniques. Upon release, there is a significant risk that these individuals may apply the skills they acquired in prison. Thus, separating convicts according to the type and severity of their crimes is therefore essential for effective reformation.

The second suggestion is to improve press engagement at all levels of government. In a democratic system, there should be a strong

and transparent relationship between citizens and the government. Some political officeholders consistently avoid interviews with journalists, sending representatives instead. Holding a political office should not exempt one from accountability or communication.

Granting press interviews demonstrates two things: first, that government activities are conducted transparently, and second, that the officeholder is competent. Individuals involved in suspicious activities are likely to avoid media interaction. The success of a government should not be measured solely by praise from political allies but by feedback from citizens and even political opponents.

While a political officeholder cannot personally receive feedback from every citizen, the press serves as the people's mouthpiece, making it easier to gauge public opinion. In the modern era, press conferences should be interactive, allowing journalists to ask questions about various aspects of governance. Citizens often feel more comfortable communicating concerns through journalists rather than directly submitting petitions to the government.

The overarching goal of press engagement is to build and maintain trust between government and citizens, ensuring that governance is transparent, accountable, and responsive to the public.

Thirdly, religious bodies and associations in Nigeria ought to be properly regulated. Many societal issues are influenced by religion. Although official records often mention two major religions in Nigeria,

the country actually has three: Christianity, Islam, and traditional religions.

The government needs to regulate religious practice to create a unified understanding of religious activities. Religion is interpreted differently by different people, and when some individuals justify violence or harm in the name of religion, it becomes a serious problem. While attention is often given to issues associated with Christianity and Islam, the challenges posed by traditional religions should not be ignored.

Reports frequently describe killings for ritual purposes, the discovery of human body parts, and attempts to take lives for ritual sacrifices. Some traditional bodies continue to believe in sacrificing human beings. Similarly, certain churches and mosques employ violent practices in the name of deliverance or disturb public peace with excessively loudspeakers. In extreme cases, individuals justify harming or killing others based on religious beliefs.

In a society where such practices occur, strict regulation of religious activities is essential. Proper regulation would ensure that individuals committing violent acts face legal or psychiatric interventions. Regardless of how religion is practiced, three principles should always be observed: religious beliefs should not be imposed on others, no one should be harmed for religious purposes, and human life should never be taken in the name of religion.

Finally, the use of social media in Nigeria requires certain regulation. Social media plays a critical role for individuals, businesses, and government, but misuse can create significant problems. Many people exploit the ease of creating accounts under false identities. Based on the survey conducted for this study, only four out of ten social media users in Nigeria register accounts using their real names.

Although public figures such as politicians, religious leaders, professionals, and business owners often use their real identities online, many other users deliberately conceal theirs. For instance, someone named Olugbodi Emmanuel on their official identity card may use “Emily Dave” on social media. Some even assume a different gender online. Such anonymity facilitates fraud, harassment, the spread of fake news, sharing of inappropriate content, and other illegal activities.

To promote peace and accountability, all social media accounts should be regulated, and legal standards established for all users.

In conclusion, the mindset of government at all levels should go beyond merely addressing existing problems. Effective governance also involves taking proactive measures to prevent issues from arising, and, in my view, this constitutes the hallmark of good governance.